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Migration, Remittances, and Household Strategies*

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Keywords

migration, transnationalism economic life, economic well-being, social life

Abstract

In this review, I examine the meaning, place, and role of remittances for migrants (movers) and for their sending households and communities. I define remittances as more than economic and explore the cultural and social value of remittances as well as the ways in which transnational space is created as movers and nonmovers interact. Although remittances are often critical to the well-being and survival of migrant sending households, this review also defines the costs that movers face as they remit and the positive as well as negative impacts remittances can hold for sending households.

INTRODUCTION

The importance of remittances to the economic well-being of immigrant workers, their households, and their sending communities is undeniable (World Bank 2006). The OECD (2005) estimates that \$126 billion flowed from migrant workers to their sending households, communities, and countries in 2005, an amount well in excess of the total official aid directed to the developing world by donor nations. Although the formal, legal transfers noted by these studies support nonmovers, their communities, and countries (Ratha et al. 2008), the remittance estimates in these studies do not include informal, unofficial, and illegal transfers (Christiansen 2008, Lozano Ascencio 1998, Mohan 2002, Shehu 2004) or engage in debates concerning the goals of remittance practices for nations and the relationship of national development to local practices (Adams 2009, Castles 2009, Iskander 2010, Kinoti 2006, van Doorn 2004). Furthermore, these reports do not typically look beyond the economics of migration to the sociocultural impacts of remittance practices or the benefits and costs of these practices for movers and nonmovers.

Remittance practices are the outcomes of cultural traditions and social practices. They are rooted in the strengths and weaknesses that drive individual migrants and their sending households and communities (Brown & Poirine 2005, Eversole 2008, Helweg 1983, Singer et al. 2008). I use anthropology to frame remittance practices as one of the many transnational flows that link movers and nonmovers and sending and receiving communities through complex social and cultural ties (Brettell 2003, Paerregaard 2008, Trager 2005b, Vertovec 1999).

Remittance research tends to focus on the large and expensive big-ticket items that migrants send to their communities of origin (Smith 2006); it often ignores the fact that some returns are not wanted and that sometimes movers make small, economically insignificant contributions (Cliggett 2005, van Doorn 2004), whereas other movers send nothing at all and choose to leave their networks (Qian 2003).

Migrants who do remit are not driven by an inchoate force to act; rather, they remit because they choose to do so (Mora & Taylor 2006). Typically, movers who remit gain socially through their actions, earning status vis-à-vis their sending community, and exercise tempered altruism and enlightened selfishness (see discussion in Lucas & Stark 1985). Thus, although migrants remit and support their sending households and communities, they are also compensated for their efforts: burnishing their social status and amplifying identities as they negotiate new destinations (Stodolska & Santos 2006).

MIGRATION AND REMITTANCES

Remittances are defined as economic transfers that follow unidirectional paths from a mobile worker to her or his sending household, community, and country (Maimbo & Ratha 2005); however, remittances are about more than the formal unidirectional flow of money (Carling 2008). The economics of remittance practices is important to sending countries [influencing the balance of trade and supporting national investments, as is clear in Adams (1991), de Haas (2005), and Skeldon (2008)], but remittance outcomes are rooted in migration and founded in the connections movers share with their sending households and destination communities (Guarnizo 2003, Massey & Akresh 2006).

Remittances are important for the role they play in sending households that lack local opportunities (Mazzucato et al. 2008, Yang & Martínez 2006). They are also important to the movers who send resources. The flow between movers and nonmovers, and destination and sending households (Gamburd 2008, Rose & Shaw 2008), defines the transnational space in which remittance practices occur (Vertovec 2009, p. 66). This space reproduces the social universe and cultural traditions of sending households and communities, the realities of the mover's life, the migration process, and the reception by destination countries

(Eversole 2005, Lindley 2010, Lubkemann 2005, Parreñas 2005, Schmalzbauer 2008, Stodolska & Santos 2006).

Movers face unique challenges that are defined by their abilities, mobilities, destinations, work, and countries of origin (Al-Sharmani 2006, DaVanzo 1981, De Jong 2000, Ryan et al. 2009). All movers have strengths and weaknesses such as age, gender, experience, and ability. Young women moving from rural hometowns face a series of challenges that are unique from challenges that confront young men (Curran et al. 2005, Fomby 2005, Gamburd 2008, Kanaiaupuni 2000, Lutz 2010, McDowell 2004, Van Hear 2010). Whereas the highly skilled migrant is welcomed by a destination country (Cornelius et al. 2001), the unskilled migrant often finds he or she must negotiate a border, remain unassimilated, and accept low-wage work (Hartmann 1976, Manning 2002, Millard & Chapa 2004). Regional and internal movers also face a different set of challenges than those that confront international migrants (Trager 2005b). Internal movers tend to remit less, but they are not negotiating borders. Nevertheless, an internal sojourn can be destabilizing for movers (think of the Chinese immigrant who travels from the west to factories on the eastern coast). Refugees and displaced persons represent additional categories and alternative challenges that revolve around the impacts of social and environmental disasters as they seek safety and opportunities (Al-Sharmani 2006, Moorehead 2005, Valentine et al. 2009, Van Hear 2006).

REMITTANCE PRACTICES

Migrants move and remit for myriad reasons: Some travel and remit freely, whereas others have few choices and hope to find opportunities. Yet all move in relation to households, and even those who decline to remit make decisions that impact households and the communities left behind (Grasmuck & Pessar 1991). Whereas some sending households are never satisfied with the efforts of their mobile members, there are some migrant workers who

plan to remit regularly but cannot (Ramirez et al. 2007, Sanchez 2007, Tatla 2002). And remittance practices change over time and as migrants engage in new jobs, establish new relationships, and enter new stages of their lives (Al-Sharmani 2006, Bacallao & Smokowski 2007, Boehm 2008, Foner 1997, Heymann et al. 2009, Levitt & Lamba-Nieves 2011, Oropesa & Landale 1997, Schmalzbauer 2008).

First-time movers tend to cover their expenses before they can begin to remit (Al-Sharmani 2006, Guarnizo 1997, Kandel & Kao 2000), whereas younger movers and movers with young children earmark a good deal of their remittances to support everyday expenses back home (Stark 1992, Trager 1984). Settled immigrant workers who hold reasonably steady jobs often earn more money and earn that money more consistently than do new, less settled immigrants (Hernandez & Coutin 2006, Portes 2007), which often translates to more consistent and larger remittances. Returns from these movers cover more than the costs of daily living and the purchase of consumer goods (Cohen & Rodriguez 2005, Newell 2005). Established households with older, settled movers can use their remittances to make investments that create new opportunities (Brown & Connell 1994, Conway 2007, Lopez & Seligson 1991, Sørensen et al. 2002, Stahl & Arnold 1986, van Doorn 2004); nevertheless, the majority of remittances are directed toward the challenges of daily life (Suro et al. 2002).

Remittances from migrants tend to grow over the short term and for about five years, increasing as the income of the migrant rises and as her or his work becomes more regular. Remittances can decline or decay over time and as the ties linking movers and nonmovers are strained (Gammage 2006, Lowell & de la Garza 2002). Remittances also decline as the length of the migrants' stay in a destination country increases and as families are established or reunited in their destination countries (Amuedo-Dorantes et al. 2005, Orozco 2002b). Altruism on the part of the mover, support of a community's traditions, and family pressures can mediate some decline

in remittance rates, and researchers have, in fact, found that remittances often do not decay or decline but instead continue to flow from movers to nonmovers over time even crossing generational barriers (Brown 1998).

The variation in remittance practices over time and in relation to a sojourner's situation can make it difficult to define the impact that remittances have on sending households, communities, and countries (Brettell 2007). Many countries now celebrate their migrants and the money they return. In several countries (including Brazil, El Salvador, and Turkey, for example), remittances are one of the top sources of investment capital (Landolt 2001) supporting national governments and local development and countering declines in direct foreign aid during economic crises (see Buch & Kuckulenz 2010, Lianos & Cavounidis 2010).

Remittances also challenge the way individuals think about themselves. Remittances provide nonmovers with the opportunity to demand higher wages, access new opportunities (including education and better health care), and reject the status quo (Gamburd 2008, King et al. 2006, Wong 2006). Where remittances are invested locally, informal economic growth can open new opportunities for nonmovers (Brown & Connell 1994), and human capital expands as nonmovers use the returns made by immigrant workers to rethink familial organization, economic life, and political opportunities (Brown & Poirine 2005, Hirsch 2003).

We should not assume that all remittances work to improve the situation for sending households. Remittances can displace local incomes and increase local inequalities, drive consumptive spending, and inflate prices, among other things (Vertovec 2009). Nonmovers who rely on remittances are sometimes caught in a web of dependency and consumerism that can develop into what some researchers term a migrant "syndrome" as local opportunities fail to materialize (Binford 2003, Reichert 1981).

Remittances, particularly large remittances, create opportunities and support local development schemes and investments; yet many migrants cannot afford to return large sums to

their homes. Some of these migrants are internal movers who earn relatively little as parts of national workforces in countries with low wages and restricted job markets (Borjas 2006, Gullette 2007, Skop et al. 2006). In a weak labor market where low wages are paid, the internal migrant may remit, but at a rate far lower than compatriots who cross international lines and find higher wages in foreign countries (Campbell 2010, Liang & White 1996, White 2009). Other migrants may cross national lines, yet find low wages as they move regionally, as is often the case with sub-Saharan African movers (Castles 2009, Mazzucato et al. 2008, Triandafyllidou 2009). Gender also complicates remittance rates (King et al. 2006). Migrant women often find service jobs that pay less than what their male comigrants earn (particularly if they work as nannies or maids), and they often juggle a job against maintaining a home for other migrants, robbing them of time for additional work (Al-Sharmani 2006, Brumer 2008, Curran et al. 2005, Gilbertson 1995, Livingston 2006, Pantoja 2005). Even as we focus on the importance of remittances in the economic life of sending communities, it is critical to remember that mobility is not always a response to economic need; it can reflect other insecurities, including ethnic conflicts and natural disasters that fuel refugee movement and, in the process, encourage remittances as stay-behinds struggle to cope and rely on movers for support (Lindley 2010, Sirkeci 2005).

BEYOND ECONOMIC TRANSFERS

Remittances are one part of a system of strong transnational connections that link people over distances and around diverse cultural practices (Georges 1990, Grigolini 2005, Moran-Taylor 2008a, Newell 2005, Styan 2007). Remittances reflect and build the social status of the sender as funds flow to support not just family, but also community, local government, development, and traditional practices as well as celebrations (Ali 2007, Cohen 2004, Paerregaard 2008, Suzuki 2006).

The connections created through remittance practices are sometimes surprising and beg the question of why immigrant workers continue to return funds to their households, particularly when these individuals may be second- or third-generation children of migrants with few ties to their homeland (Oropesa & Landale 1997, Orozco 2002a). The reality is that even though remittances track from an immigrant sender to her or his home and community, they are about more than economics. The children of movers often continue the cycle of remittances (though often sending less money or periodically sending goods) and support a homeland (a homeland that will often grow more mythical with time) as a way to declare their own value and worth vis-à-vis their destination country's cultural traditions (Paerregaard 2008). Remittances are appreciated and celebrated even as they create obligations among individuals who may not know one another, and the remittances that flow from migrants and their children to sending households are often returned as sending households and communities work to maintain connections over time (Boehm 2008, Dreby 2006, Gamburd 2008, Heymann et al. 2009).

Returned goods, gifts, services, and the like, regardless of their real value, are a kind of repayment for the effort made by the remitting migrant, and they have both direct and indirect effects (Colton 1993, Lubkemann 2005, Rose & Shaw 2008). The returned gift motivates and reminds the immigrant worker of the family and friends left behind who depend on her or him for support. Other times, the returned resources are part of an elaborate reciprocal system that uses nostalgia to build linkages between the children of immigrants and their former sending hometowns (Georges 1990, Stodolska & Santos 2006). The remittances and the goods and services returned to the mover create strong, long-lasting transnational bonds that connect movers and nonmovers (and see Smith & Guarnizo 1998).

The circular flow of remittances, goods, services, and information reassures and

refocuses efforts so that movers and their children do not lose sight of connections with their hometowns, even as the generations build over time (Kana'iaupuni et al. 2005, Parreñas 2005, Ryan et al. 2009). Researchers have documented cases of second-generation children of migrants who are connected through family, friends, and traditions to hometowns they may never visit (Foner 2002, Kasinitz et al. 2004, Levitt 2002, Portes 1998). These connections are often formalized around hometown associations (HTAs). The reach and influence of HTAs should not be underestimated and include support for development initiatives that establish school and universities (Mohan 2002), health clinics (Hagan 1994, Lowell & de la Garza 2002), and sports facilities in sending communities (see Portes 2003).

The flows between migrants and their sending households and communities are not equal. There are few ways that sending households can match the value of the remittances that migrants return. Yet, at a social and cultural level, the gifts, goods, and information that are forwarded to movers by sending households are critical to the survival of the migrant and her or his children. For undocumented migrants who face criminal prosecution if they are caught, the goods and phone calls from family and the support that comes from a sending household and community are crucial to psychological well-being (Chavez 1994). Even small gifts can serve to invigorate links between movers and nonmovers, and the information and connections that nonmovers share with movers can help them as they search for jobs, friends, and support (Aleman-Castilla 2007, Connell 2008, Hashim 2007, Ley & Kobayashi 2005, Moran-Taylor 2008b, Sanchez 2007, Schmalzbauer 2008). These connections can even serve to help a migrant manage her or his remittance schedule as family in origin communities share news of their needs, statuses, and challenges faced. Finally, remittances can be repaid when migrants face economic challenges themselves as when family members in origin communities send money to support children living across national borders who encounter new hardship

because of global economic crises (see the special issue of *Migration Letters* on remittances and economic crises in Ratha & Sirkeci 2010).

CONCLUSIONS

Remittances are more than economic. They are critical to the social and cultural well-being of movers and nonmovers of small rural communities and nations (Ratha et al. 2008), and remittances must be understood for their benefits as well as their costs. Remittances are of fundamental importance to many migrant-sending households as they cope with poor local economies, limited job markets, and low wages (Suro et al. 2002). The pull of opportunity in destination countries (whether the United States, Western Europe, or elsewhere) tends to relieve some of the pressures on sending nations to improve labor practices and wages and to develop local economies (Cohen 2001, Stodolska & Santos 2006). Yet success can drive an increase in overall migration rates that leaves nonmovers in an increasingly dependent

position (Binford 2003) and can challenge movers who cannot meet their own or others' expectations (Duke & Gómez Carpinheiro 2009). Because remittances do not flow equally, there is also a risk of increased inequality locally as households with movers differentiate themselves from nonmovers (Adams & Page 2005, Burawoy 1976, Jones 1998, McKenzie 2006, Semyonov & Gorodzeisky 2008). Remittances are not thrown away on consumer goods and luxury items (Taylor 1999). Rather, remittances are critical in unanticipated ways to local economies as the members of sending households improve their households; spend on education, health care, and rituals; engage in local politics; and invest in small business. Even as migration rates shift and movers appear from new and heretofore understudied sending regions, remittances will likely continue to be important as will the need for ethnographic and anthropological research that can follow new ways of connecting migrants and nonmigrants and of understanding the flow of goods, services, information, and money.

SUMMARY POINTS

1. Remittance practices are related to migration outcomes, strengths, and weaknesses of the mover and origin, as well as destination communities.
2. Remittances are rooted in migration decision making.
3. There are benefits and costs to remittance practices for movers and nonmovers.
4. The flow of remittances creates and maintains transnational space for movers and nonmovers.
5. Nonmovers often return resources (food, information, etc.) when they receive remittances from movers.
6. Remittances are overwhelmingly tied to the well-being of sending households; however, they can also drive development.

FUTURE ISSUES

1. Several issues are critical, yet understudied, in the anthropology of migration including the dynamics of and difference between internal and international movement and the continued value of transnational models in the discussion of migration and remittance outcomes.

2. We need more research on shifts in remittance practices beyond the second generation and in terms of gender and religion as well as the role of HTAs.
3. The recent economic crises highlight the importance of remittances, yet we need more ethnographic work on how movers and nonmovers adapt to economic change and how remittance practices change in response to economic crises.

DISCLOSURE STATEMENT

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